

Chapter 7: Solving Problems

from Leading Others

by Mac Lake

¹ Jennifer Robison, "In Praise of Praising Your Employees," Gallup, November 9, 2006, <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/236951/praise-praising-employees.aspx> (accessed January 14, 2020).

² Roger Schwarz, "The 'Sandwich Approach' Undermines Your Feedback," Harvard Business Review, April 19, 2013, <https://hbr.org/2013/04/the-sandwich-approach-undermines> (accessed January 8, 2020).

7

Solving Problems

Who likes problems? Nobody! But when you step into leadership, problems come with the territory. Of course this happens at work and in your home, but church is no exception; even when you are leading in the church, problems are an inherent part of your role. For instance:

- Three of your team members call in sick at the last minute on Sunday morning, leaving you short-handed in your ministry area just as the worship service is about to begin.
- An irate parent is yelling at you because the coat her child came in with is missing.
- Someone in your small group is going to different individuals in the group and asking them to loan him money.

Situations like these can disrupt the normal flow and results of what you're doing. It is your job to take the lead in handling these situations. If you don't, the problem will grow—feelings will be hurt, resentment will develop, gossip will begin to spread, and negative attitudes will begin to form.

Don't worry: you're in good company. As you scan the Bible, you find godly leaders facing problems all the time. Moses had grumbling followers. David was chased down by the king. Esther had to take her life in her hands to stop a massacre. Paul experienced shipwreck, team members that abandoned him, and much more. (For a long list of his problems, see 2 Corinthians 11:23–33.)

The good news is that God gave these leaders wisdom and perseverance to deal with the problems they faced. Not only that, but he went beyond what they could handle to make a way for them to overcome. David's testimony was that "the righteous person may have many troubles, but the Lord delivers him from them all" (Psalm 34:19).

Problems are built into our fallen world, but they also have a place in God's plan to build us into maturity. Problems have a way of building your leadership confidence and credibility when you handle them the right way.



Character: Wisdom

Leaders thoughtfully respond to situations in ways that honor others, bring mutual understanding, and yield the best results.



Competency: Problem Solving

Find wise solutions to challenging situations that could cause disruption.

Objectives

- 1.** Devise practices to increase your reliance on God's wisdom in all areas of life.
- 2.** Reorient your perspective to recognize the possibilities in problems.
- 3.** Assess your ability to handle the four types of common problems.

4. Practice solving a problem using the five guidelines provided in this training.
5. Teach someone what you are learning about problem solving.



Deepen Your Character: Wisdom

As leaders it is easy to follow our natural inclinations and instincts in a given situation, but that is not always the wise thing to do. If we only default to handling a challenge according to the well-worn groove of our personality type or react from our emotions in the moment, we could make a bad situation worse. Wisdom is always needed when you encounter problems as a leader.

One of the wonderful things we learn about God in Scripture is that he is generous with his wisdom. James says, “If any of you lacks wisdom, you should ask God, who gives generously to all without finding fault, and it will be given to you” (James 1:5). So if God so generously gives his wisdom, we should passionately seek to gain it. As you do this, you will notice that you handle difficulties in ways that honor others, bring mutual understanding, and yield the best results.

Scripture

As you read the following Scripture, meditate on what the author wishes to communicate, and answer the questions below. Allow the Holy Spirit to speak to you and challenge you as a leader about how you can develop your character so that you are wise in your everyday life.

Proverbs 3:5–8

Trust in the LORD with all your heart
and lean not on your own understanding;
in all your ways submit to him,

and he will make your paths straight.
 Do not be wise in your own eyes;
 fear the LORD and shun evil.
 This will bring health to your body
 and nourishment to your bones.

What are three warning signs that someone is leaning on their own understanding?

On a scale of 1 to 5, score yourself on how much you are trusting the Lord and submitting to his ways in the following areas of your life:

- Personal well-being _____
- Work _____
- Family _____
- Other relationships _____
- Community and church participation _____
- Leisure time _____

What obstacles or pressures keep your lowest score low?

What practical change can you make to raise your lowest score?

Now that we have examined the character trait of wisdom, we can now begin to work through the core competency for this module: *Find wise solutions to challenging situations that could cause disruption.* As you read what follows, note how wisdom can undergird a leader's competency of problem solving.



Develop Your Competency

Problem Solving

Preassessment

Before proceeding, complete the assessment below. In the final module of this training guide, you will retake it as a postassessment to measure your transformation and growth in this competency.

The following proficiencies demonstrate mastery of this module's competency. For each of them, give yourself a grade of A, B, C, D, or E to reflect your actual level of competency today. Giving yourself an A+ indicates you are a model for others to follow. An E indicates no mastery.

Proficiency	Preassessment
Have an emotionally and spiritually healthy response to problems	
Address problems without passing blame or diminishing people's feelings	
Find the root of a problem before trying to solve the problem	
Identify a list of options when addressing a problem	
Communicate the plan to all those involved and affected by the problem	

Reflection Questions

I tend to make
decisions too slow

I tend to make
decisions too fast

Where are you on this continuum? Which way do you need to move and why?

In my early days as a leader, I always used to look at problems as negative experiences to be avoided at all costs. They triggered uncomfortable emotions like anxiety, frustration, sadness, or anger in me. Sometimes I reacted instinctively out of those emotions, and the results weren't good.

In time, however, I learned that when problems are handled the right way, they make us smarter, they give us greater understanding of one another, and they unify us against a common threat. Problems can actually be a positive thing when they are handled correctly.

I'll never forget one example of this that permanently changed my ministry for the better. My team was running an important training event when one of the participants got very upset. His name was Rhino. (No kidding—that was what everyone called him.) I learned quickly that he didn't get the name just because he looked like a rhino but because he had the attitude of a rhino!

During one session, I could tell from Rhino's demeanor and body language that he was about to boil over with anger. This could have been a disaster in front of the rest of the participants. So my co-leader

and I walked him out into the hallway. I said to Rhino, "I can see you are upset. Can you tell me what happened to make you feel this way?"

It is worth noting that Rhino's role that day was to silently observe and support his friend who was the active participant in the training we were doing, so until we went into the hallway together, Rhino wasn't in a position to say anything. That's part of the reason he was steaming. So once I invited him to take the lid off, he began heatedly detailing why he disagreed with our process. He felt that his friend was treated unfairly and that he himself was being impacted negatively. Now, as far as we could see, everyone was being treated the same way, but Rhino saw it differently. I have learned that someone's perception may not actually be reality, but it functions as reality to them. So we let Rhino get everything on his mind out in the open. We acknowledged the way Rhino was feeling and apologized that he was having that experience.

Now, if that was where the story ended, it would have been an unpleasant moment then and a bad memory now. But after the event we gathered our team and talked the situation over. As we spent time analyzing and evaluating together, we discovered some gaps in our process that we could improve. Once we made those adjustments, it made our program much stronger not just for future "Rhinos" but for everyone who participated in our process. We built a whole new tool that took our training to a higher level.

We never would have made those major upgrades to what we were doing if it hadn't been for the problem with Rhino. So don't curse your problems, because problems contain possibilities.

When you encounter problems, how do you instinctively react?

Give more than one answer.

When have you witnessed or experienced a problem becoming a possibility?

Four Types of Problems

As you lead, you will encounter four types of problems.

1. Relational problems. These come about when people don't understand, don't see eye to eye, don't appreciate, or don't respect one another, and as a result they get upset with one another.

2. Resource problems. These involve a shortage of what you need to accomplish your mission, whether of money, people, or tools. Resource problems are demoralizing because they make the team feel like they are trying to accomplish their task with one hand tied

behind their back. When a resource-deficient team doesn't have everything it needs, its leader needs to resourcefully adapt and find ways to keep things moving.

3. Execution problems. Helmuth von Moltke the Elder, the Prussian chief of staff before World War I, made a statement that has been famously paraphrased this way: "No plan survives contact with the enemy." Leaders have to be able to adapt because nothing goes the way you think it will when you actually get into it. (Someone forgets the hot dogs for the cookout, the weather doesn't cooperate, and so on.) Doing nothing or complaining won't solve the problem, so leaders have to be ready to adapt and adjust.

4. Criticism problems. Sometimes the problem you have to solve arises from someone's complaint or criticism. While it may be unjustified, unfair, or unwarranted, in most cases you need to address the problem so it doesn't infect your team or group with negativity.

Which type of problems are you usually most prepared to solve?

How did you become capable of solving those problems?

Which type of problems are you usually least prepared to solve?

What hinders you from addressing those problems effectively?

What practical step can you take to overcome the difficulties you have addressing that type of problem?

Common Mistakes When Dealing with Problems

One problem with problems is that they can spawn a bigger problem! This comes about when you don't handle a problem well. Then you have a whole new problem: people lose confidence in your leadership.

The first step in handling problems well is to recognize and avoid common mistakes. Don't misunderstand—all of us leaders have made them. But you have the opportunity to learn from the experiences of people who have been leaders before you. The most common mistakes are the following.

1. Ignoring the problem. Some leaders see or hear of a problem but choose to ignore it. Ignoring problems is choosing not to lead. When you don't address a situation, especially when others recognize it, it damages people's trust in your leadership.

2. Acknowledging the problem but not solving it. There's no faster way to lose your credibility with someone than acknowledging a problem that they have brought to your attention, listening to them, and sympathizing with them, but then failing to follow through with any solutions or action.

3. Passing blame. Sometimes leaders feel insecure when problems arise in their area of leadership. Rather than taking ownership of the problem and seeking to rectify it, they immediately look for someone to blame—"I don't know why the church doesn't fix that" or "I told Jim to handle that; it's his responsibility." As a leader you will often be blamed for things you didn't directly contribute to, but your team or group needs you to ignore that and focus on the problem that needs to be solved.

4. Diminishing people's feelings. People often get emotional when a problem affects them. Next time you call a customer service line with something that needs to be fixed, notice what they say. A representative recently replied to me, "Mr. Lake, I am sorry you are

experiencing this problem; I know how frustrating that can be when your phone isn't working properly. Let's see what we can do to get this resolved today." In three sentences, she won me over. Just remember to be sincere—people can tell when you don't really care and are just going through the motions.

Which common mistake have you made the most in the past?

How might this mistake sabotage your leadership?

If these are the most common things *not* to do, how are you supposed to handle problems? Here are a few guidelines to put into practice when they arise.

Guidelines for Solving Problems

1. Get to the Root

It's hard to solve a problem when you haven't declared what it is. That may sound too obvious to matter, but in truth, many problems aren't solved because they aren't adequately understood. A team settles for a simple definition of the problem that seems correct, but it is actually only the surface issue. The real problem is hidden several layers down.

Sakichi Toyoda, the founder of Toyota Industries, is credited as the father of a simple but ingenious tool called the 5 Whys. The technique is simply to ask "why?" of a problem five times in a row to get to the root cause.

For example, if you're a worship leader, you may look out in the congregation one week and see that people aren't singing along very much. So you go to a friend who isn't on the worship team and you ask why (#1). She says, "It was hard to sing along because the lyric slides weren't keeping up with the music. I didn't know the song from memory, so I had to wait until the words were put up before I could sing along, and by that time half the slide was sung."

From there you talk to the person who was operating the slides that day and ask why the slides were lagging behind the music (#2). He says, "I'm not sure; I've never seen behavior like that before. I was clicking on time, but it wasn't moving on time."

From there you talk to the person who administers that computer. You ask why the computer might have been lagging behind (#3). The administrator thinks about it for a second and then says, "I wonder if it got an operating system update. I know a new one came out. Maybe that had something to do with it." He checks the computer and confirms that this was indeed the case.

"Why would a new operating system be a problem?" you ask (#4).

The administrator replies that the new OS requires a lot more of the computer's resources, and this old computer is not powerful enough to handle it and manage the presentation software at the same time.

Then you ask, "Why do we have a computer too old to run the software we need?" (#5). The administrator directs you to the leader of the church's IT team. The leader says she was unaware that you needed a new computer and asks you, "Did you include a request for a new machine when you submitted your ministry budget request for this year?"

"Wait, that computer comes out of *my* budget?" you ask. That leads to a conversation with the church's financial manager that enlightens you as to what technical hardware you have responsibility for and how to request money to maintain and replace it. In the end, you learn that the way to prevent the problem of people not singing during worship is to make an ample annual budget request for technical equipment. (And in the meantime you work with the slides operator to figure out a way to make do until the new computer comes in.)

By drilling down to the root of the issue, you are able to do more than solve problems—you are able to prevent new ones from arising.¹

2. Consider the Options

Once you have clearly defined the problem, next consider your options. Don't just grab the first option, but brainstorm a variety of possibilities. Aim to stretch yourself; set a target number of options that is more than you think you can come up with.

Not all options may be good options, but I have discovered that when I list options, sometimes it is actually a combination of options that end up being the wise solution.

3. Seek Counsel

Different problems have different levels of complexity. Some problems are simple and simply need a quick intervention to get things back on track. Others are more complex and require more time, processing, and input.

Sometimes you face a problem that would benefit from the counsel of your group or team. Some leaders are afraid that if they do this they will appear weak, because it will be obvious that they don't have it all together. But seeking counsel is a wise thing to do and is actually a sign of strength. Seeking counsel gives you different perspectives that you would not see on your own. Gaining these different perspectives may expand your options and enable you to resolve the problem in a more peaceful or effective manner.

The best part about seeking counsel in your group or team is that if you introduce it the right way, it activates their ownership in the situation. If you talk about it as "*our* problem" instead of "*my* problem," they will offer better ideas and be more glad to pitch in to implement the solution.

4. Make a Decision

Sometimes leaders make a situation worse by not committing to a decision. Some leaders are afraid of the consequences that might follow their decision, so they put it off as if they hope the problem will go away or solve itself. But our inaction or procrastination can actually exacerbate the problem. We have to recognize that there is actually no such thing as not making a decision, because putting it off is effectively deciding in favor of the status quo.

But how do you know that your decision is the right one? Many times you will not be 100 percent confident that your solution is perfect. But you want to rest assured that you did what you believed

would best serve the mission and honor God according to whatever information you had at that time, even if not everyone agrees with your decision or you have lessons to learn in the end.

Warren Buffett has given his managers at Berkshire Hathaway a simple rule of thumb to help them make ethical decisions that they can live at peace with. He calls it “the newspaper test.” The test consists of a single question: “How would you feel about your decision if a smart but unfriendly reporter wrote a story about it in tomorrow’s newspaper, and it was read by your family, friends, and neighbors?” If you can live with the result, go for it; if not, think again.²

5. Communicate

John Maxwell says, “Most people are down on what they’re not up on.”³ When you make a decision that solves a problem, it is critical that you communicate the solution. Follow these basic steps to ensure good communication.

a. Make a plan. Think about the outcome you are hoping for and work backward from there to figure out how you are going to communicate your message, including where, when, and by what communications method and medium.

b. List your audience. This means every person who will be responsible to implement the solution, *and* (importantly) everyone who is going to be affected by it.

c. Justify the solution. When you communicate, first state succinctly what the problem is and what the consequences will be if it is not addressed. Next state the outcome you are aiming to achieve. Then state the solution itself in the clearest possible terms.

d. Prepare for questions. Many people don’t care about the details of how you reasoned through your decision, but some people

do. Be ready to answer their questions about facts and alternatives you considered and your rationale for making the choice you did.

e. Detail the impact. For some of your audience that means delineating who is responsible to do what and what will be expected of them. For others it means preparing people for how things will change for them (with appropriate sympathy, if the situation requires it).⁴

Problems aren't always easy to deal with, but God has given you much more power to solve them than you might realize. Following basic guidelines like these goes a long way toward strengthening your credibility with the people you lead. Remember: problems yield possibilities!

Design a memory device to help you remember the five guidelines of solving problems.

Put It into Practice

Developing a new skill requires practice. Before you get together with your trainer, complete the following assignments to help you practice giving feedback.

1. Identify a small problem at work or at home. Address it by following the five guidelines of solving problems. After you take the steps, write down at least one part of your intervention that went well and one thing you would do differently.
2. Find someone in your life who is experiencing a problem. Listen patiently and show understanding and compassion. Gently share with them that you are learning about how to solve practical problems, and ask them if they would be willing to let you help. If so, gently guide the person through the five steps.

Reflect on Your Learning

In what aspect of this competency did you grow the most?

What next step do you need to take to continue to grow in this competency?

Meet with Your Trainer

Consistent practice can be a great beginning to sharpening a skill, but developing a skill also requires processing what you learned with others. Meet with your trainer and discuss what you learned from this module.

¹ For more on using the 5 Whys, see "5 Whys: Getting to the Root of a Problem Quickly," Mind Tools, https://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newTMC_5W.htm (accessed April 3, 2020).

² Tom Popomaronis, "Billionaire Warren Buffett Has a 'Simple' Test for Making Tough Decisions—Here's How It Works," CNBC Make It, <https://www.cnbc.com/2019/05/10/billionaire-warren-buffett-use-this-simple-test-when-making-tough-decisions.html> (accessed April 3, 2020).

³ John C. Maxwell, *Leadership Gold: Lessons I've Learned from a Lifetime of Leading* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2008), 166.

⁴ Adapted from Chris Ruisi, "Communicating the Decision," Monday Morning Wake-Up Call, <http://archive.constantcontact.com/fs160/1011278201010/archive/1115689983158.html> (accessed April 3, 2020).